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College basketball: Results from the Schwab Invitational **D4** | **Outdoors:** Bill Monroe's column **D10** | **NFL** **D11**

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2008 THE YEAR IN REVIEW

Best story of the year gives everyone a lift

The great debate began and ended last April when Western Oregon right fielder Sara Tucholsky hit a softball over the fence, tore a ligament in her right knee as she was rounding first base, and was left crawling in the dirt, unable to touch the bases.

This year I saw Usain Bolt run faster than any man before. I watched Michael Phelps win eight gold medals. The Trail Blazers have been promising. The Civil War was electric.

And this state hosted a delightful Olympic Track and Field Trials and also a stunning upset of No. 1 USC in college football, but if we're being real, the biggest story in the year of sports went down on that softball diamond at Central Washington in Ellensburg.



JOHN CANZANO
COMMENTARY

Tucholsky crawled back to first base. Then the umpires huddled and ruled that a pinch runner could replace her at first base, resulting in a two-run single.

And maybe you know by now that instead, two opposing players from Central Washington ran from their dugout, lifted Tucholsky and carried her around the bases with tears streaming down the faces of the players in both dugouts.

What happened between those teams, and the women involved was inspiring. And authentic. And sportsmanlike. Tucholsky got her home run and the rest of us got chills, and that's about as just and fair an exchange as there exists in the world of sports. And its impact lasted well beyond the game.

It gets ugly in sports. Drugs. Cheats. Lies. Police being called to Little League fields. Hockey dads punching each other out. The calendar flips, and the scandals keep coming. But when we think about what happened between those softball teams, we can't help but ask ourselves if there isn't something to be learned by all of us about the human condition and how it relates to sport.

What happened that day is undeniable. And what happened next tells you about the fabric that joins us, and keeps us together, because when I called Tucholsky to tell her that the moment she shared with those two Central Washington players was the best in sports this year, she said, "No way!? Really?!?!"

Yes, kid. Really.

Please see **CANZANO,** Page D4

Sun Bowl
No. 24 Oregon State vs. No. 18 Pittsburgh

Punter gets his kicks as a fighter

Pittsburgh's Dave Brytus, who competes in mixed martial arts, puts on a crowd-pleasing display

By KEN GOE
THE OREGONIAN

EL PASO, Texas — Pittsburgh punter Dave Brytus broke up the traditional players' pre-Sun Bowl talent show.

Literally.

The 6-foot-4, 230-pound senior, a cage fighter when not playing football, put on a wood- and concrete-breaking demonstration Friday night that got roars from the players on both teams.

"I broke like 12 boards, and then I broke three cinderblocks stacked up on each other," Brytus said Saturday after the Panthers' practice at the Socorro Athletic Complex. "People seemed to really like it, because it's something unique. People don't see martial arts performed every day like that."

Brytus, who makes a deceptively laid-back first impression, even caught some of his teammates by surprise.

"I knew he was a fighter," Pitt tailback LeSean McCoy said. "But that was kind of scary, because I'm messing with him all the time. Now I know I'm not messing with him anymore after that demonstration last night. He's always talked about how he can do that, but I didn't take him seriously."

When Brytus began his demonstration, it brought, shall we say, a different dimension to the talent show.

"There were people singing and playing the piano and stuff like that, but nothing that had a real physical aspect," Brytus said.

Just how tough are the Panthers, anyway?

You might expect Scott McKillop, Pitt's All-America middle linebacker, to start pulverizing cinderblocks with his bare hands. But the punter?

Please see **OSU,** Page D7

Next up
No. 24 Oregon State vs. No. 18 Pittsburgh, 11 a.m. Wednesday, El Paso, Texas (TV on KOIN 6/CBS; radio on KPAM 860)

College football
Quarterback Pat White makes history in West Virginia's 31-30 win over North Carolina in the Meineke Bowl | **D7**

A season that started in sadness over the death of **Todd Doxey** is ending Tuesday in the beloved former safety's hometown



Ducks will close circle for 'Teeder'

By JEFF SMITH
THE OREGONIAN

SAN DIEGO — She keeps the card on the nightstand next to her bed, reading it every time she wants to hear his voice and feel his presence.

It's a Mother's Day card from May 2007, when Gladys Doxey was moved to tears by the profound words written inside by her grandson during his freshman year at the University of Oregon.

Dear G-Mom,
First I want to say thank you for always being in my life in me and my sister's time of need. I know, just like everyone else knows, that you are the glue holding our family together. I want to let you know you are appreciated. You are my driving force inside. You're the reason I work as hard as I do. I love you.
Love,
Teeder

"He always called me G-Mom," Gladys Doxey said, laughing, while clutching the card in her San Diego home. "Teeder was so good to me."

"Teeder" was Todd Doxey, who lived most of his young life with his grandmother. Doxey, a former redshirt freshman safety for the Ducks, drowned July 13 after a swimming accident in the McKenzie River in Springfield. He was 19.

A week after Doxey's death, several players and coaches from the UO football team were among the estimated 2,500 people who attended Doxey's memorial at The Rock Church in San Diego.

Five months later, the 15th-ranked Ducks' emotional season has brought them back to Doxey's hometown, where they will play No. 12 Oklahoma State on Tuesday in the Holiday Bowl.

Please see **UO,** Page D6



THOMAS BOYD/THE OREGONIAN
Todd Doxey works out in UO spring practice last April, about three months before his fatal swimming accident in the McKenzie River.

Holiday Bowl: No. 15 Oregon vs. No. 12 Oklahoma State, 5 p.m. Tuesday, San Diego (TV on ESPN; radio on KXL 750)

The Blazers
Portland 102, Toronto 89

Next up: Boston at Portland, 7 p.m. Tuesday (TV on CSN Comcast 37, radio on KXTG 95.5)

Blazers listen up, sound off with win

Brandon Roy and Greg Oden lead the way as Portland rallies past Toronto after Nate McMillan's call for better communication

By JASON QUICK
THE OREGONIAN

Long before the Trail Blazers dispatched Toronto 102-89 on Saturday night — before Brandon Roy went on one of his fourth-quarter tears and Greg Oden (finally) looked like a top draft pick — coach Nate McMillan brought up an important topic in the pregame locker room.

Communication was the subject, and volume was the emphasis.

This Trail Blazers team is a very tight-knit group off the court, but as it turns out, the guys have had problems communicating on the court, particularly on defense. Screens by the opponents were going unannounced. Team rules on pick and rolls — going under or through a screen — were not being voiced. And assuring voices of help defense were muted.

As a result, the Blazers defense has suffered, so much so that McMillan termed the team's latest defensive outing against Dallas as "bad. Really bad."

So before Saturday's game in front of 20,588 at the Rose Garden, McMillan had a plan. As he addressed the team at the front of the room, he walked to the back, where a glass refrigerator sits with Gatorade and bottled water.

From there, he asked Oden and starting small forward Nicolas Batum to give their scouting reports on the Toronto players they would guard.

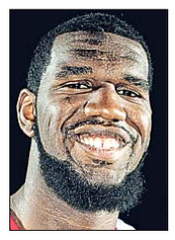
Two of the quietest players on the team, Oden and Batum each gave their report. Still standing by the refrigerator, McMillan made his play.

"He told us 'Look, there are going to be 20,000 people out there, you need to talk louder,' " Oden said.

Please see **BLAZERS,** Page D8



32
Points for **Brandon Roy** who led the Blazers in scoring



16-10
Greg Oden's points and rebounds against Toronto

Online
Follow Oregonian beat writers Joe Freeman and Jason Quick with the Blazers behind the beat blog at **blog.oregonlive.com/behindblazersbeat/**

Commemorative posters: Order special 13x19 prints honoring the Class 6A, 5A and 4A state championship seasons of Southridge, West Albany and Astoria for $25 by contacting The Oregonian's photo sales desk at **503-294-4086.** Information on how to order online coming soon.

UO notebook

Holiday Bowl is special to Gundy

By MIKE TOKITO
THE OREGONIAN

SAN DIEGO — Don't think Oklahoma State coach Mike Gundy has a competitive streak?

Consider his reaction when a reporter relayed a comment made by linebacker Andre Sexton. Sexton had wondered if the 41-year-old Gundy had actually played football for the Cowboys.

"Early in his career, I wasn't sure he played, either," Gundy said with a smile after the Cowboys' practice Saturday at the University of San Diego. "He's done a little better now."

This week, there is plenty of evidence that Gundy played for the Cowboys, who play Oregon in the Holiday Bowl on Tuesday. Gundy had the game of his career in the 1988 Holiday Bowl, when he completed 20 of 24 passes for 315 yards and two touchdowns and ran for 41 yards to lead the Cowboys to a 62-14 win over Wyoming.

Gundy's 83.3 completion percentage remains a Holiday Bowl record, and he has been inducted into the game's Hall of Fame, a distinction he shares with former Cowboys teammate Barry Sanders, who ran for 222 yards and five touchdowns in that 1988 game.

Gundy still holds the Oklahoma State records for career passing yards (7,997) and total offense (7,749), although his current quarterback, junior Zac Robinson, could pass him in both categories next season. Gundy said it doesn't bother him at all that his players might not appreciate his place in school history or his performance the last time the Cowboys played in the Holiday Bowl.

"People mention that about the Holiday Bowl, but these guys, they weren't even around back then," he said after the Cowboys practice at the University of San Diego.

There are several similarities between this year's Oklahoma State team and the 1988 squad that played in the Holiday Bowl 20 years to the day before this year's game. The 1988 win gave Oklahoma State 10 wins for the season, something the Cowboys (9-3) would achieve for the first time since if they beat Oregon.

The 1988 game had Sanders, Gundy and a standout receiver in Hart Lee Dykes. This year's team is led by Robinson, first-team All-American receiver Dez Bryant and all-Big 12 Conference running back Kendall Hunter.

Johnson returns: Oregon running back Jeremiah Johnson returned to practice Saturday and proclaimed he would be fit to play in the Holiday Bowl.

"Everything is cool, back to normal," Johnson said after practicing at San Diego State. "I'll be ready to go Tuesday."

Johnson injured his left hamstring in practice Dec. 22 and hadn't practiced before Saturday. He said he still had some tightness in the hamstring.

"But I can go off that," he said. "It's really not that big of a deal."

Johnson was supposed to practice Friday, but came down with a different health problem.

"I had a little stomach virus, throwing up, and a headache and body ache," he said.

Taking more time to recover was starting tackle C.E. Kaiser, who sat out his second consecutive practice with symptoms similar to Johnson's.

"He still wasn't feeling good this morning," Oregon coach Mike Bellotti said. "We're hopeful that he'll break today and he'll have a couple days to recover completely and get out here and practice."

Kaiser also missed the final practice in Eugene on Monday because of a concussion, and he still has not been cleared to play Tuesday.

Up in the air: One position that seemed settled after the Civil War remains up in the air. Bellotti said that field goal and extra-point kicking remain unsettled.

Junior Morgan Flint handled field goals and extra points the final three games of the season and was 18 for 18 on PATs and 7 for 7 on field goals in those games. However, Bellotti said Saturday that the decision on who kicks Tuesday — Flint or senior Matt Evensen, who handles kickoffs — isn't settled.

"It's heartbreaking being here, but there is some closure to this because of Grandma and the strength she gives everybody above herself."

– UO secondary coach John Neal

UO: Family and friends will attend game

Continued from Page D1

For the Ducks, it's more than a bowl game. It's a unique opportunity for closure.

"I get chills just thinking about that," Oregon senior running back Jeremiah Johnson said. "That's just God working right there.

"I mean, we could have played in any bowl game. But He put us here so T-Dox could play with us. I truly believe that his soul is in San Diego, so it's going to be like we'll have a 12th man on the field for us."

Doxey is expected to be honored on the big screen during the game, and sophomore cornerback Talmadge Jackson III will wear Doxey's No. 29 for the designated "home team," continuing the tradition this season of a different Oregon player wearing the number during home games.

Jackson, who grew up 60 miles north of San Diego in Murrieta, Calif., remembers watching Doxey's high school highlights on television and couldn't wait to meet him when he became his college teammate.

"He was a legend around here," Jackson said. "Just a pure athlete. I'm so proud I get the opportunity to wear his number and I hope I make his family proud."

About 25 members of the Doxey family — plus countless friends — are expected to attend Tuesday's game and most will be wearing No. 29 jerseys. That includes Gladys Doxey, 65, who will be attending her first football game at Qualcomm Stadium.

The proud grandmother is elated to have Oregon in her beloved city, but also she can't help feeling a certain sadness. After all, the Ducks are practicing this week at San Diego State, which is three miles from where Doxey starred in football and basketball while earning a 3.5 grade-point average at Hoover High School.

"Teeder would just be jumping from the walls if he was here," she said. "He would be so excited. His college playing in his hometown? He would be beside himself, just overjoyed."

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Gladys Doxey also knows that if Todd Doxey were here, he would be worried about her.

Gladys Doxey, who has overcome two battles with lung cancer in the past 10 years, is awaiting biopsy results on her lymph nodes that could show a return of the deadly disease.

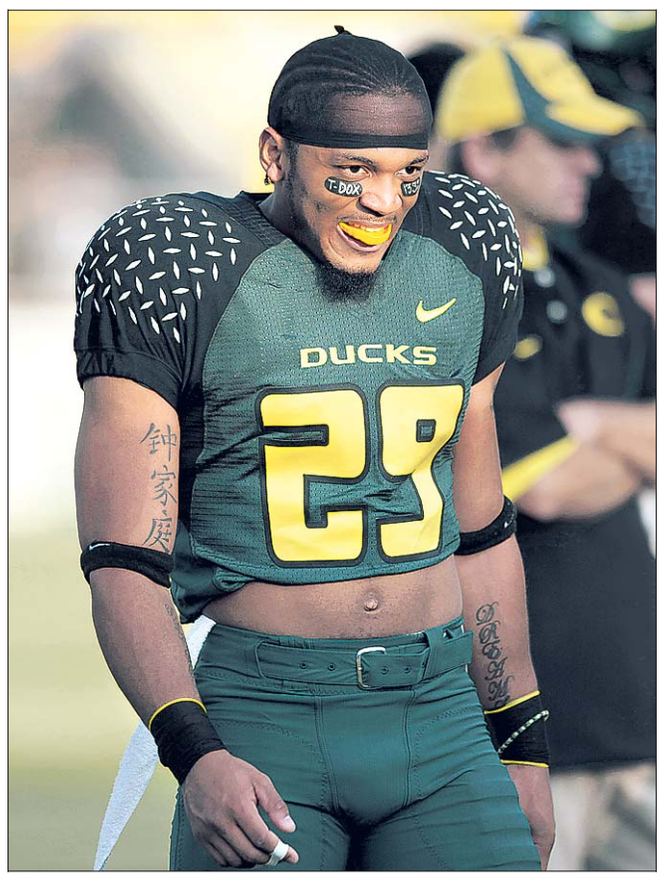
"He used to always tell me, 'Grandma, I want you to live forever,' " Gladys Doxey said. "He was kind of overprotective of me. I used to tell Teeder, 'I'm not going nowhere,' and that's how I still feel. I feel great. If it's cancer again, then so be it and we'll take care of it and go to the next step. As long as I wake up every day, then life is good. I'm OK."

Such optimism is what immediately endeared Gladys Doxey to the Oregon football team. Two days after Todd Doxey's death, Gladys Doxey spoke to the players at a private memorial service in the Casanova Center in Eugene.



NANCEE E. LEWIS/SAN DIEGO UNION-TRIBUNE

An estimated 2,500 people attended a memorial service for Todd Doxey on July 13 in San Diego. Todd Doxey's grandmother, Gladys Doxey (pictured top left), will be attending her first game at San Diego's Qualcomm Stadium Tuesday night for the Holiday Bowl to honor him.



THOMAS BOYD/THE OREGONIAN

Patrick Chung wore Todd Doxey's No. 29 jersey in Oregon's season opener against Washington on Aug. 30. A different Ducks player wore the number in each of the team's games during the season.

She also attended Oregon's season-opening win over Washington at Autzen Stadium on Aug. 30, which probably would have been Todd Doxey's collegiate debut after sitting out the 2007 season as a redshirt.

As the season has gone on, Gladys Doxey has watched as many Ducks games as she could — "I never really followed football before this," she said — and she has stayed in close contact with UO secondary coach John Neal.

Neal, who met Gladys Doxey during the recruiting process, credits her with bridging the gap between San Diego and Eugene this season. While most of the early focus was on dedicating the season to Todd Doxey, much of the motivation lately has been on honoring the woman that everybody on the team calls "Grandma."

"It's heartbreaking being here, but there is some closure to this because of Grandma and the strength she gives everybody above herself," Neal said. "She's really the story because she's had to bring two families together, the family down here and the family in Oregon. There were a lot of people searching for what to do after this happened. Her strength overcame everything and made us all better people from it.

"When the times were at its worst, she was at her best."

Hoover High basketball coach Ollie Goulston has seen this side of Gladys Doxey for 16 years, since he began coaching the oldest of her 15 grandchildren. Goulston, who also coached Todd Doxey, has practically become a member of the Doxey family in that span and visited them on Thanksgiving and Christmas.

"She's a true matriarch," Goulston said. "She holds everything together for everybody. She has such a great spirit. She really is the rock of the family and has such a great way of comforting people."

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Todd Doxey was laid to rest at Mount Hope Cemetery, three blocks from his grandmother's modest four-bedroom home in Logan Heights — an area of the city that has seen its share of heartache.

On his headstone are five photos of Doxey and the quote, "God's on my side."

Those were Doxey's final words to teammate Will Wallace before making the fateful jump from the 40-foot bridge that would lead to his death. Those words comfort Gladys Doxey when she makes her biweekly visit to the graveyard to restock the flowers and keep the area clean.

She also makes sure that nobody touches the graffiti mural — reading "R.I.P. Todd" in giant, colorful letters — that neighborhood children created in the alley next to her house on the night of Doxey's death. The same goes for the flower pot, photos and San Diego Padres ballcap that are displayed in Doxey's honor at one end of a long white fence outside her home.

"Everybody was thinking that Todd was going to make it big in sports, but he made it big in a different way," Gladys Doxey said. "Everybody still talks about him."

But she also understands that life must go on. The Ducks probably won't continue the No. 29 jersey tradition next season as a new team forms its identity.

"This completes the circle that we started at the beginning of the season," Oregon coach Mike Bellotti said. "We're going to get a chance to add to his memory, but it's sort of sad because it really does finish that chapter to a degree. What an impact he made on people's lives."

It's an impact that Goulston has seen from students at Hoover, with many using Doxey as inspiration to avoid the "many bad influences" of the street and stay on the right path. That impact is also seen in Doxey's younger cousins and siblings as many of them now have aspirations also to attend the University of Oregon when they graduate from high school.

Perhaps the most poignant impact Todd Doxey has made can be seen in the warmth and calmness of Gladys Doxey. In the months since the accident, she has enjoyed learning more about her grandson through his former school papers and through stories told by his teammates and friends.

Tuesday's game might bring closure to the Oregon football team, but there is no ending in sight inside a certain photo-filled home on 33rd Street in San Diego.

"He never walked out of this house without kissing me and saying, 'I love you,' " Gladys Doxey said. "I'll never forget that. My mom used to always say, 'You aren't dead until you forget.' Teeder will never be dead to nobody in this family because we'll never forget him."

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Jeff Smith: 503-221-8546; jeffsmith@news.oregonian.com

Dispatch from San Diego

Resurgent Chargers are center of attention in town

You'll have to forgive this city for lacking Holiday Bowl hype.

After all, today happens to be the "AFC West Championship Game" featuring two teams with a combined 15 losses. What, you're not excited, too?

Yes, the 7-8 San Diego Chargers have become the center of the sports world down here as they prepare to play the 8-7 Denver Broncos at 5:15 p.m. at Qualcomm Stadium. A home playoff game goes to the winner while the loser heads into the offseason.

These are the same Chargers that most fans had written off three weeks ago when they were 4-8.

My high school friend, Chris Jacobs, recently moved from Portland to Chula Vista to work for the border patrol. He is a die-hard Broncos fan who has become disgusted with the "stupid fairweather bandwagon fans down here that only like their teams when they're good."

No clearer example of that is the ticket prices for tonight's game. As recently as one week ago, you could easily log on to Internet sites and find seats for well below face value.

Now, single tickets for the sold-out game are being listed for $250-$1,400. Also, an increasing number of Chargers flags are being spotted on cars, and sports talk radio and local television is filled with discussion about the game.

As for the Holiday Bowl? I asked a couple of sports fans on the campus of San Diego State who would win the game and their response basically summed up the mood of this city:

"Oh yeah, that game is Tuesday, huh? Sorry, haven't really followed that."

I turned to walk away before hearing, "Hey dude, do you have a ticket connection for the Chargers?"

— Jeff Smith